AI-Powered CPL Student Story Capture System

Pilot Proposal (Main Document)

Contents

Work Flowchart **4**

1. Problem Statement **5**
- 1.1 Heavy Reliance on Manual Staff Effort . . . 5
- 1.2 Lack of Scalability Across Colleges and Populations . . . 5
- 1.3 Inconsistent Story Quality and Formatting . . . 5
- 1.4 Bottlenecks in Review, Approval, and Publishing . . . 6
- 1.5 Risk of Falling Short of Strategic Storytelling Goals . . . 6

2. Proposed Solution (Conceptual Design) **7**
- 2.1 Core Concept . . . 7
- 2.2 Student Interview Experience . . . 7
- 2.3 AI-Assisted Story Drafting . . . 8
- 2.4 Student Review, Editing, and Approval . . . 8
- 2.5 Photo and Consent Collection . . . 8
- 2.6 Output: Publish-Ready Stories . . . 9
- 2.7 Design Principles . . . 9
- 2.8 Why This Approach Works . . . 10

3. Exploratory Work Conducted to Date (Pre-Pilot Validation) **11**
- 3.1 Purpose of the Exploratory Phase . . . 11
- 3.2 Scope and Limitations of Exploratory Work . . . 11
- 3.3 Key Findings from Exploratory Validation . . . 12
- 3.4 Why This Exploratory Work Strengthens the Proposal . . . 13
- 3.5 How This Informs the Proposed Pilot (Next Sections) . . . 13

4. Formal Pilot Proposal: What Approval Is Being Requested **14**
- 4.1 Purpose of the Pilot . . . 14
- 4.2 What the Pilot Will Test . . . 14
- 4.3 What the Pilot Is *Not* . . . 16
- 4.4 Scope and Scale of the Pilot . . . 16
- 4.5 Why a Pilot Is the Right Next Step . . . 16
- 4.6 Transition to the Proposed Workflow (Next Section) . . . 17

5. Proposed Pilot Scope **17**

5.1 Pilot Participants . . . 17
5.2 Pilot Duration . . . 18
5.3 Interview Modalities Tested . . . 18
5.4 Expected Pilot Outputs . . . 18
5.5 Pilot Evaluation Metrics . . . 19
5.6 Controlled Scope and Risk Management . . . 19
5.7 Transition to Workflow Description (Next Section) . . . 20

6. Proposed Technical Architecture (Planned Implementation) 21
6.1 High-Level System Overview (Plain Language) . . . 21
6.2 Frontend: Student Interview Interface . . . 22
6.3 Backend Services: Interview Orchestration & State Management . . . 23
6.4 AI Components: Conversational Logic and Narrative Generation . . . 24
6.5 Secure Storage: Text, Audio, Photos, and Consent . . . 25
6.6 Security, Privacy, and Governance Considerations . . . 25
6.7 Why This Architecture Was Chosen . . . 26
6.8 Transition to Next Section . . . 26

7. Proposed Student Workflow (End-to-End Experience) 27
7.1 Step 1: Invitation to Participate . . . 27
7.2 Step 2: Student Completes the Interview (Text or Voice) . . . 27
7.3 Step 3: System Generates a Draft Story . . . 28
7.4 Step 4: Student Reviews and Edits the Draft . . . 28
7.5 Step 5: Student Approves and Locks the Story . . . 29
7.6 Step 6: Student Uploads Photo (Optional) . . . 29
7.7 Step 7: Student Reviews the Publish Preview . . . 29
7.8 Step 8: Final Submission for MAP Publishing . . . 30
7.9 Summary of Student-Centered Design . . . 30
Transition to Next Section . . . 31

8. Governance & Controls (Proposed Framework) 32
8.1 Student Consent and Ownership . . . 32
8.2 No Automatic Publishing . . . 32
8.3 MAP Editorial Authority . . . 33
8.4 Communications Review and Oversight . . . 33
8.5 Auditability and Accountability . . . 34
8.6 Summary of Governance Principles . . . 34
Transition to Next Section . . . 34

9. Evaluation Criteria (Proposed Pilot Assessment Framework) 35
9.1 Student Participation and Completion . . . 35
9.2 Story Quality and Consistency . . . 35
9.3 Engagement Modality: Voice vs Text . . . 36
9.4 Staff Time and Operational Efficiency . . . 36
9.5 Readiness for Scale . . . 36
9.6 Pilot Evaluation Outputs . . . 37
Transition to Next Section . . . 37

10. Next Steps (Upon Approval) **38**
10.1 Confirm Pilot Cohort . . . 38
10.2 Finalize Student Interview Question Set . . . 38
10.3 Align Publishing and Communications Workflow . . . 38
10.4 Launch Pilot (Limited Deployment) . . . 39
10.5 Review Outcomes and Determine Scale-Up Path . . . 39
10.6 Summary of Decision Flow . . . 40
Transition to Closing . . . 40

11. Why This Proposal Matters **41**
11.1 From Manual Effort to Sustainable Capability . . . 41
11.2 A Foundational Building Block, Not a One-Off Tool . . . 41
11.3 Low Risk, High Learning Value . . . 41
11.4 Alignment with MAP's Strategic Goals . . . 42
11.5 Why Proceed Now . . . 42
11.6 Closing Perspective . . . 42

Work Flowchart

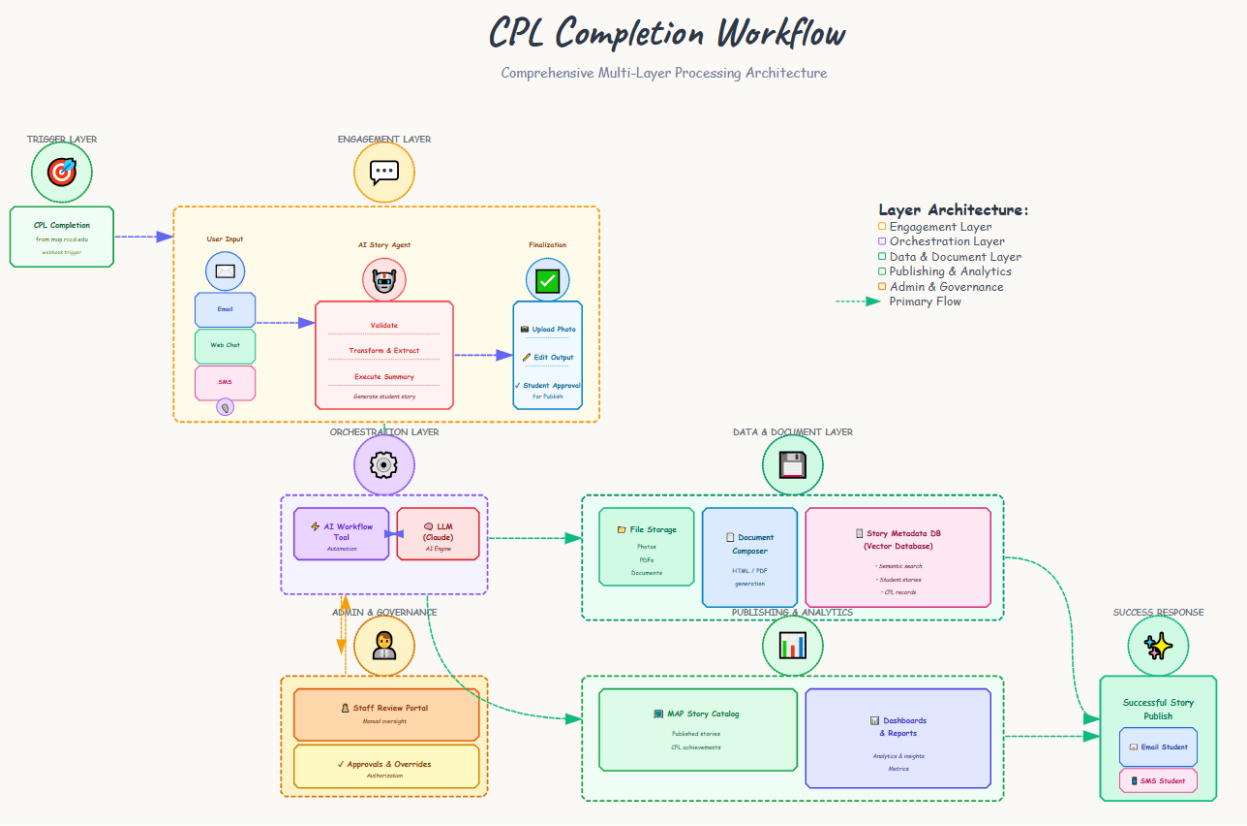

Figure 1: Flowchart

1. Problem Statement

MAP has identified student stories as a **critical narrative and communications asset**—not only for showcasing Credit for Prior Learning (CPL), but also for demonstrating equity, workforce alignment, and student-centered success across the California Community Colleges system.

However, the **current approach to collecting student stories is not designed to operate at scale**.

1.1 Heavy Reliance on Manual Staff Effort

Today, most student stories are collected through **manual, staff-driven processes**, which typically include:

- Identifying a student who might be willing to share their story
- Coordinating schedules for interviews
- Conducting live interviews (often by counselors or communications staff)
- Transcribing, drafting, and editing narratives
- Following up for clarifications, approvals, photos, and consent

Each story represents **multiple handoffs** and repeated staff involvement. While this approach works for a small number of stories, it becomes unsustainable when scaled statewide.

1.2 Lack of Scalability Across Colleges and Populations

MAP's long-term goal of collecting **1,000 student stories by 2030** cannot be met using processes that require high-touch human coordination for each individual student.

Key scalability challenges include:

- **Limited staff capacity** at colleges and district offices
- **Inconsistent local practices** for outreach and interviews
- No systematic way to invite *every eligible student* to participate
- Difficulty expanding story collection beyond CPL to other student populations

As a result, story collection remains **opportunistic rather than systematic**, depending on who has time, interest, or local support.

1.3 Inconsistent Story Quality and Formatting

Because stories are collected manually by different people across locations:

- Story structure varies widely
- Key narrative elements (background, impact, outcome) may be missing
- Formatting is inconsistent, increasing editorial cleanup work
- Stories may not align cleanly with MAP's publishing standards

This inconsistency creates additional work downstream for communications teams and slows the publishing pipeline.

1.4 Bottlenecks in Review, Approval, and Publishing

The current process also creates **bottlenecks**:

- Students may need multiple follow-ups to approve content
- Photo and consent collection is often delayed or incomplete
- Communications teams must reconcile drafts, permissions, and formats before publishing

These bottlenecks limit how quickly MAP can move from “story collected” to “story published,” even when interest exists.

1.5 Risk of Falling Short of Strategic Storytelling Goals

Without a scalable, student-centered solution:

- MAP risks falling significantly short of its long-term storytelling goals
- Valuable student voices may go uncollected
- Storytelling efforts may remain uneven across colleges and regions
- Equity-focused narratives may be underrepresented simply due to process constraints

In short, **the challenge is not a lack of compelling student stories**, but the absence of an infrastructure that allows those stories to be collected, reviewed, and published efficiently.

2. Proposed Solution (Conceptual Design)

To address the scalability, consistency, and sustainability challenges outlined above, we propose the development of a **lightweight, AI-assisted student storytelling platform** designed specifically for MAP's needs.

This platform is **not intended to replace human judgment or storytelling values**. Instead, it acts as a structured, student-centered workflow that captures authentic student voices while significantly reducing staff burden.

At a high level, the system introduces a **guided, self-service storytelling experience** for students, supported by AI only where it adds efficiency and consistency.

2.1 Core Concept

The proposed solution enables students to share their story through a **short, structured interview** that they can complete on their own time, using either text or voice.

Rather than relying on live interviews or manual follow-ups, the system:

- Guides students step-by-step through carefully designed questions
- Uses AI to assemble a clear, well-structured draft story
- Ensures students remain in full control of what is shared and approved
- Returns a publish-ready story to MAP with minimal manual processing

This approach shifts story collection from a **staff-driven process** to a **student-driven experience**, while preserving MAP's editorial and ethical standards.

2.2 Student Interview Experience

Students interact with the system through a simple, conversational interface that:

- Presents one question at a time
- Uses plain, student-friendly language
- Allows responses via:
  - **Typed text**, or
  - **Recorded voice responses**, which are securely transcribed

The interview is intentionally short and focused, designed to capture:

- The student's background and prior experience
- The CPL moment (what was recognized and by whom)
- The impact of CPL on the student's path
- The student's next steps or outcomes

Students can complete the interview in one session or return later, reducing pressure and improving participation.

2.3 AI-Assisted Story Drafting

After the interview is complete, the system uses AI to:

- Organize the student's responses into a coherent narrative
- Align the structure with MAP's existing storytelling standards
- Preserve the student's original wording as much as possible
- Clearly flag any missing information for follow-up (rather than inventing content)

Importantly:

- **The AI does not add facts**
- **The AI does not infer or embellish**
- **The AI does not bypass student review**

Its role is editorial and organizational—not creative or interpretive.

2.4 Student Review, Editing, and Approval

Before anything is finalized or shared:

- Students are shown the full draft story
- They can:
  - Edit wording directly
  - Clarify or expand sections
  - Decide whether the story accurately represents them

Only after explicit student approval does the story move forward.

This review step ensures:

- Accuracy
- Student agency
- Trust in the process
- Alignment with consent and ethical storytelling principles

2.5 Photo and Consent Collection

Once a story is approved, students are guided through:

- Optional photo upload
- Clear consent choices, including:
  - Consent for publication
  - Consent for inclusion in PDFs or reports

Consent is:

- Explicit
- Recorded

- Stored alongside the story for auditability

Students may also choose to **skip photo submission** without blocking the story itself.

2.6 Output: Publish-Ready Stories

The final output of the system is a **publish-ready student story** that:

- Has been reviewed and approved by the student
- Includes all required permissions
- Follows a consistent narrative structure
- Can be returned to MAP for publishing with minimal additional editing

This dramatically reduces the time and effort required by communications teams while improving consistency and throughput.

2.7 Design Principles

The proposed system is intentionally designed to be:

Student-Centered

- Students control their narrative
- Students approve final content
- Students choose how and when to participate

Consent-Driven

- No publishing without explicit approval
- Clear, auditable consent records
- Ethical use of student voice and likeness

Secure and Auditable

- All actions (responses, edits, approvals) are logged
- Data handling follows institutional security standards
- Clear separation between draft, edited, and approved content

Extensible

While initially focused on CPL stories, the same framework can be extended to:

- Veterans
- Rising Scholars
- Apprentices
- Foster Youth

- Other MAP-aligned student populations

This makes the platform a **foundational building block**, not a one-off solution.

2.8 Why This Approach Works

This proposed solution directly addresses MAP's current constraints by:

- Reducing staff time per story
- Enabling consistent, repeatable story collection
- Increasing student participation
- Preserving quality, consent, and trust
- Creating a scalable model aligned with MAP's long-term goals

It represents a shift from **manual storytelling efforts** to a **modern, student-powered narrative**.

3. Exploratory Work Conducted to Date (Pre-Pilot Validation)

Before requesting formal approval to proceed with a pilot implementation, a **limited, non-production exploratory phase** was conducted to validate whether the proposed concept was *feasible, responsible, and aligned with MAP workflows*.

This exploratory work was intentionally scoped as **proof-of-feasibility**, not a build-out of a finished system. Its purpose was to reduce risk, avoid rework, and ensure that any proposed pilot would be grounded in practical reality rather than theory.

3.1 Purpose of the Exploratory Phase

The exploratory phase was designed to answer a single guiding question:

> **Is this idea technically viable, scalable, and aligned with MAP's existing storytelling and publishing workflows?**

Rather than investing staff time or requesting formal pilot approval prematurely, this phase allowed the team to test assumptions and identify potential constraints early.

Key goals of this phase were to:

- Validate that students could meaningfully participate without live staff involvement
- Confirm that AI could assist *without* compromising authenticity or consent
- Identify technical or workflow barriers before proposing a pilot
- Ensure alignment with MAP's ethical, communications, and operational standards

3.2 Scope and Limitations of Exploratory Work

It is important to emphasize what this phase **was and was not**.

What this exploratory work *was*:

- A controlled, internal feasibility exercise
- Focused on workflow logic, not polish or scale
- Designed to test assumptions, not finalize solutions
- Conducted without public-facing deployment
- Used only test or simulated data

What this exploratory work *was not*:

- A production system
- A student-facing deployment
- A replacement for formal MAP review or approval
- A commitment to specific technologies or vendors

This distinction ensures that MAP retains full decision-making authority over whether, how, and when a pilot proceeds.

3.3 Key Findings from Exploratory Validation

The exploratory phase demonstrated several critical findings that support moving forward with a formal pilot proposal.

1. Conversational Interviews Are Viable

The exploration showed that a guided, conversational interview format can reliably collect the core elements needed for student stories, including:

- Background context
- CPL experience
- Impact and outcomes
- Forward-looking goals

Students were able to engage with the process without confusion or excessive instruction.

2. Text and Voice Responses Are Functionally Equivalent

The exploratory work confirmed that:

- Students can respond using **typed text** or **spoken voice**
- Voice responses can be accurately transcribed
- Story quality does not materially differ based on response mode

This finding is critical for accessibility and inclusivity, allowing students to choose the interaction mode that works best for them.

3. AI Can Support Narrative Structure Without Altering Student Voice

The exploratory testing showed that AI can:

- Organize student responses into a clear narrative structure
- Align drafts with MAP-style storytelling formats
- Preserve the student's original wording and intent

Just as importantly, it demonstrated that AI can be constrained to **avoid inventing content**, reinforcing trust and accuracy.

4. Student Review and Approval Can Replace Manual Mediation

A key validation outcome was confirming that students can:

- Review a generated draft
- Edit content directly

- Approve or withhold consent without staff involvement

This step is essential to maintaining ethical standards while significantly reducing staff workload.

5. Photo Upload and Consent Can Be Managed Securely

The exploratory phase also confirmed that:

- Optional photo submission can be integrated cleanly into the workflow
- Consent can be explicitly collected and recorded
- Stories can proceed with or without photos, based on student choice

This flexibility aligns with MAP's communications and equity principles.

3.4 Why This Exploratory Work Strengthens the Proposal

Rather than pre-empting MAP's decision-making, this exploratory phase:

- Reduced uncertainty around feasibility
- Clarified where human oversight remains essential
- Identified which parts of the workflow truly benefit from automation
- Informed a more realistic, responsible pilot design

As a result, the proposal that follows is **better grounded, lower risk, and more transparent** about what a pilot would involve.

3.5 How This Informs the Proposed Pilot (Next Sections)

The findings from this exploratory work directly inform:

- The proposed workflow design
- The recommended pilot scope
- The choice of technology components
- The emphasis on student review and consent
- The decision to keep the pilot lightweight and iterative

Importantly, these findings do **not** lock MAP into a specific implementation — they simply demonstrate that the concept is viable and worth formal consideration.

In summary, this exploratory phase served as a responsible due diligence step.
It confirms that the proposed approach is *possible*, *aligned*, and *worth piloting*, while leaving all strategic and governance decisions.

4. Formal Pilot Proposal: What Approval Is Being Requested

This proposal formally requests approval to proceed with a **limited, structured pilot implementation** of an AI-assisted student story collection system for MAP.

The pilot is designed to move beyond conceptual validation and into **real-world testing**, while remaining intentionally small, governed, and reversible.
It is not a full production launch, nor a commitment to long-term deployment.

Instead, the pilot serves as a **learning phase** that allows MAP to evaluate the approach using real student participation, real stories, and real workflow conditions—before deciding whether and how to scale.

4.1 Purpose of the Pilot

The purpose of the pilot is to determine whether the proposed approach can:

- Deliver high-quality, authentic student stories
- Improve efficiency compared to current manual methods
- Provide a positive, accessible student experience
- Integrate cleanly into MAP's existing publishing and communications workflows

The pilot is intended to **inform decision-making**, not to replace existing processes prematurely.

4.2 What the Pilot Will Test

The pilot will focus on validating five core areas.

1. Student Experience

The pilot will test whether students can:

- Understand the invitation to participate
- Complete the interview asynchronously (on their own time)
- Choose between text or voice responses
- Review, edit, and approve their own story
- Provide consent confidently and transparently

Special attention will be paid to clarity, accessibility, and student agency.

2. Story Quality and Consistency

The pilot will assess whether stories produced through the system:

- Meet MAP's narrative and communications standards
- Maintain a consistent structure while preserving individual voice
- Are suitable for public-facing publication with minimal revision

This evaluation will involve MAP communications and content stakeholders.

3. Staff Time and Operational Impact

A central goal of the pilot is to understand operational efficiency.

The pilot will measure:

- Reduction in counselor or staff interview time
- Reduction in back-and-forth editing cycles
- Time required for review and publishing compared to current methods

This data will help MAP assess return on investment and sustainability.

4. Workflow Alignment With MAP Publishing

The pilot will test how well the proposed workflow aligns with MAP's existing processes, including:

- Triggering story collection after CPL transcription
- Reviewing and approving student-submitted content
- Managing photos and consent
- Handing off finalized stories for publication

Any misalignments identified during the pilot will inform future refinements.

5. Production of Real, Publishable Stories

The pilot is expected to produce a **small number of real, publishable student stories**, subject to MAP's approval.

These stories will:

- Be student-approved
- Include documented consent
- Follow MAP storytelling guidelines
- Serve as concrete examples for evaluating success

The focus is on quality and learning, not volume.

4.3 What the Pilot Is *Not*

To avoid confusion, it is important to clarify what this pilot does *not* represent.

The pilot is **not**:

- A statewide rollout
- A permanent replacement for human storytelling work
- A commitment to specific vendors or platforms
- A public-facing launch without MAP oversight

MAP retains full authority to pause, modify, or discontinue the pilot at any point.

4.4 Scope and Scale of the Pilot

The pilot will be intentionally limited in scope, for example:

- A small number of participating students
- One or a small number of colleges or programs
- A defined pilot timeframe
- Clearly defined success and evaluation criteria

Exact scope details will be finalized collaboratively with the MAP team before pilot launch.

4.5 Why a Pilot Is the Right Next Step

Based on the exploratory validation already conducted, a pilot is the appropriate next step because it allows MAP to:

- Move from theory to evidence
- Test assumptions with real participants
- Identify policy, communications, or governance considerations early
- Make informed decisions about scaling or adaptation

This phased approach minimizes risk while maximizing learning.

4.6 Transition to the Proposed Workflow (Next Section)

The remainder of this proposal details:

- The proposed end-to-end student workflow
- The supporting technology components
- Governance, consent, and security considerations
- Pilot evaluation and success metrics

Together, these sections describe **how the pilot would operate if approved**, while preserving MAP's flexibility and control.

In summary, this proposal requests approval to conduct a **carefully governed pilot**, designed to test feasibility, quality, and impact—before any long-term commitment.

5. Proposed Pilot Scope

This section defines the **intended scope and boundaries** of the pilot.
The goal is to clearly communicate *who* will participate, *how long* the pilot will run, *what formats* will be tested, and *what concrete outputs* MAP can expect—without overcommitting resources or introducing unnecessary risk.

The pilot is intentionally **small, time-bound, and focused on learning**, not volume.

5.1 Pilot Participants

The proposed pilot will involve a **limited group of students** who have recently received Credit for Prior Learning (CPL) awards.

Proposed Participant Profile

- **20–50 CPL students**
- Drawn from **selected colleges or programs**, identified in collaboration with the MAP team
- Students who have:
  - Recently had CPL transcribed
  - Opted in voluntarily to share their story

This limited participant count ensures:

- Manageable oversight
- High-quality feedback
- Minimal operational risk
- Sufficient data to assess feasibility without scaling prematurely

Final participant selection criteria will be confirmed jointly with MAP prior to launch.

5.2 Pilot Duration

The proposed pilot duration is:

- **4–6 weeks**

This timeframe is designed to:

- Capture enough student participation to observe patterns
- Allow for iteration based on early feedback
- Avoid long-running commitments before evaluation

The pilot timeline includes:

- Initial setup and coordination
- Active student participation
- Review and evaluation period

The pilot may conclude earlier if objectives are met, or be extended slightly if needed for evaluation purposes.

5.3 Interview Modalities Tested

To ensure accessibility and inclusivity, the pilot will test **multiple response modalities**.

Supported Response Types

- **Text-based responses**
  - Students type answers at their own pace
  - Suitable for quiet environments or preference for writing
- **Voice-based responses**
  - Students speak naturally using their device
  - Voice responses are transcribed for review
  - Supports students who find speaking easier than typing

Testing both modalities allows MAP to evaluate:

- Student preferences
- Accessibility considerations
- Differences (if any) in story quality or completion rates

Students may use either modality without affecting their ability to complete the process.

5.4 Expected Pilot Outputs

The pilot is expected to produce **tangible, reviewable outputs**, not just technical artifacts.

Primary Outputs

- **Student-approved stories**
  - Written in the student's own voice
  - Reviewed and explicitly approved by the student
  - Aligned with MAP storytelling standards
- **Optional student photos**
  - Submitted only if the student chooses
  - Accompanied by explicit consent selections
  - Managed securely
- **Consent records**
  - Clear documentation of:
    - Story approval
    - Photo consent (if applicable)
    - Publishing permissions

These outputs will allow MAP to assess real-world readiness.

5.5 Pilot Evaluation Metrics

In addition to producing stories, the pilot will generate **evaluation data** to support decision-making.

Proposed evaluation metrics include:

- Student completion rates
- Time required for story creation
- Number of staff touchpoints per story
- Quality and consistency of stories
- Student feedback (where appropriate)
- Comparison with current manual processes

These metrics will be used to determine:

- Whether the approach meets MAP's goals
- What adjustments are needed
- Whether scaling should be considered

5.6 Controlled Scope and Risk Management

The pilot is deliberately scoped to ensure:

- No disruption to existing MAP processes
- No dependency on long-term commitments
- Full MAP oversight at every stage

MAP retains the ability to:

- Adjust scope
- Pause the pilot
- Modify workflows
- Decline to proceed beyond the pilot phase

This ensures that learning occurs **without locking MAP into a solution prematurely**.

5.7 Transition to Workflow Description (Next Section)

With the scope defined, the next section describes:

- The **proposed end-to-end student experience**
- From invitation → interview → review → approval → output
- Written from the student's perspective

This workflow description will help all audiences visualize *how the pilot would actually operate in practice*.

6. Proposed Technical Architecture (Planned Implementation)

This section describes the **planned technical architecture** for the proposed pilot.
Its purpose is not to provide low-level engineering specifications, but to clearly explain:

- What major system components will exist
- What role each component plays
- How they work together to support the student experience
- Which specific tools and platforms will be used
- Why these tools were selected

This architecture is intentionally **modular, lightweight, and extensible**, allowing MAP to pilot quickly while preserving long-term flexibility.

Importantly:

- This architecture represents a **proposed implementation**
- It is informed by limited feasibility exploration
- No production deployment has occurred
- Any live use is contingent upon MAP approval of the pilot

6.1 High-Level System Overview (Plain Language)

At a high level, the system consists of four coordinated layers:

1. **Student-facing interface**
   Where students participate in the interview and review their story
2. **Backend services layer**
   Where interview logic, workflow rules, and approvals are managed
3. **AI services layer**
   Where transcription, adaptive questioning, and story drafting occur
4. **Secure storage layer**
   Where responses, media, drafts, and consent records are stored

Each layer has a clearly defined role and can be updated independently without disrupting the others.

6.2 Frontend: Student Interview Interface

Purpose

The frontend is the **only system component students interact with directly**.
Its role is to make the experience feel:

- Simple and respectful
- Self-paced
- Accessible on common devices
- Focused on storytelling rather than technology

Key Characteristics

- **Web-based interface**
  - No app installation required
  - Runs entirely in the browser
- **Accessed via secure link**
  - Delivered through email or SMS
  - No account creation or login required
- **Mobile-first design**
  - Optimized for phones
  - Works equally well on tablets and desktops
- **Supports text and voice responses**
  - Students may type answers
  - Or speak answers using their device microphone
- **Explicit review and approval steps**
  - Students see and edit drafts
  - Students explicitly approve before submission

Proposed Frontend Technology Stack

- **Framework:** Next.js (React-based web framework)
- **Hosting Platform: Vercel**
  - Managed frontend hosting
  - Automatic deployment from version control
  - Secure HTTPS by default
  - High reliability and low operational overhead

From the student's perspective, this appears as a **guided storytelling experience**, not a technical tool.

6.3 Backend Services: Interview Orchestration & State Management

Purpose

The backend services form the **control layer** of the system.
They ensure that:

- Interviews follow the intended structure
- Required story elements are collected
- Students cannot accidentally skip approval steps
- Drafts, edits, and approvals are clearly tracked

Core Responsibilities

Interview Orchestration

- Determines which question is asked next
- Tracks progress by interview section
- Handles follow-up questions when information is missing
- Supports adaptive, conversational flow (not rigid scripts)

State Persistence

- Saves:
  - Interview progress
  - Student responses
  - Draft versions
  - Approval status
- Allows students to pause and resume
- Maintains a clear audit trail

Workflow Enforcement

- Ensures:
  - Story generation occurs only after interview completion
  - Approval is required before photo upload
  - Publishing cannot occur without consent
- Prevents unintended automation

Proposed Backend Platform

- **Google Cloud Run**
  - Serverless API hosting
  - Automatically scales based on usage
  - No server maintenance required
- **Python-based API services**

    - Clear, auditable endpoints
    - Designed for readability and maintainability

This layer allows MAP to retain **full governance control**, even while using AI components.

6.4 AI Components: Conversational Logic and Narrative Generation

Purpose

The AI layer assists with **structure and clarity**, not authorship.
It helps students tell their story using their own words.

AI Capabilities Used

1. Conversational Logic Controller

- Evaluates student responses
- Determines:
    - When required information is complete
    - When clarification is needed
- Adapts the interview path without improvising content

This logic ensures **consistency and completeness**, not creativity.

2. Speech-to-Text (Voice Responses)

- Converts spoken responses into text
- Allows students to speak naturally
- Transcriptions are:
    - Presented back to the student
    - Editable before approval

Proposed Service: - Google Speech-to-Text (via Gemini or Cloud Speech APIs)

Voice input becomes standard text after transcription, ensuring equal treatment.

3. Narrative Generation Model

- Produces a **first-draft story**
- Uses only:
    - Student responses
    - Approved interview content
- Aligns to MAP storytelling structure
- Does **not** introduce new facts or embellishments

Proposed Model: - Google Gemini 2.0 flash (text generation)

All AI-generated drafts remain: - Reviewable - Editable - Rejectable by the student

6.5 Secure Storage: Text, Audio, Photos, and Consent

Purpose

All student materials must be stored **securely, transparently, and separately**, with clear ownership and access controls.

Types of Data Stored

- Text interview responses
- Voice recordings (if used)
- Transcripts
- Draft stories and edits
- Approved story text
- Optional student photos
- Consent and approval records

Proposed Storage Systems

- **Google Firestore**
  - Stores:
    - Interview state
    - Story drafts
    - Approval metadata
    - Consent flags
  - Structured for auditability
- **Google Cloud Storage**
  - Stores:
    - Audio files
    - Student photos
  - Uses:
    - Time-limited signed upload/download URLs
    - Strict access controls

Design Principles

- Separation of text and media
- No public access to raw files
- Explicit consent required before any downstream use
- Retention policies adjustable by MAP

6.6 Security, Privacy, and Governance Considerations

The architecture is designed to align with MAP's governance expectations by ensuring:

- No automatic publishing
- Clear separation between draft and approved content
- Explicit consent for photo usage
- Ability to pause or stop workflows at any point

Governance Controls

- Student approval is mandatory
- MAP retains editorial authority
- AI outputs are auditable
- Pilot can be suspended without data loss

6.7 Why This Architecture Was Chosen

This architecture was selected because it is:

- **Understandable** to non-technical stakeholders
- **Low-risk** for pilot testing
- **Maintainable** by technical teams
- **Flexible** for future populations (Veterans, Apprentices, Foster Youth, etc.)
- **Scalable** only if MAP chooses to expand

It prioritizes **experience and governance first**, technology second.

6.8 Transition to Next Section

With the technical architecture defined, the next section describes:

- The **end-to-end student journey**
- From invitation → interview → review → approval → output
- Written as a plain-language walkthrough

This ensures all audiences can clearly visualize how the proposed system would function in practice.

7. Proposed Student Workflow (End-to-End Experience)

This section describes the **intended student experience** for the proposed pilot.
Rather than focusing on technical steps, it walks through the process **from the student's point of view**, explaining:

- What the student is asked to do
- What happens behind the scenes
- How consent, review, and control are maintained at every stage

The goal is to ensure that the workflow feels **simple, respectful, and empowering**, while producing stories that meet MAP's communications standards.

7.1 Step 1: Invitation to Participate

What the student experiences

- The student receives a brief invitation via **email and/or SMS**
- The message:
  - Congratulates the student on receiving CPL credit
  - Explains that MAP is inviting them to share their story
  - Includes a **secure, personalized link** to begin

What the system does

- The invitation is triggered by a **CPL transcription event**
- A unique interview session is created for the student
- No login or account setup is required

Why this matters

- Reduces friction for participation
- Connects storytelling directly to a meaningful milestone
- Ensures equity by making participation easy and optional

7.2 Step 2: Student Completes the Interview (Text or Voice)

What the student experiences

- The student opens the link and sees a short introduction
- They are guided through a **structured but conversational interview**
- They may respond:
  - By typing answers
  - Or by speaking into their device (voice option)

What the system does

- Presents one question at a time

- Tracks progress across sections (background, experience, outcomes, impact)
- Saves responses automatically
- Allows the student to pause and resume if needed

Why this matters

- Respects different communication preferences
- Makes the experience accessible and human
- Avoids long forms or overwhelming surveys

7.3 Step 3: System Generates a Draft Story

What the student experiences

- After completing the interview, the student clicks a button to generate a draft
- The system produces a **first-draft narrative** in clear, readable language

What the system does

- Organizes the student's responses into a coherent story
- Uses only the student's own words and ideas
- Applies MAP-aligned structure and tone
- Clearly labels the result as a *draft*

Why this matters

- Reduces staff time spent writing stories
- Helps students see how their experiences translate into a narrative
- Maintains consistency across stories

7.4 Step 4: Student Reviews and Edits the Draft

What the student experiences

- The full draft appears in an editable text window
- The student can:
  - Make corrections
  - Add details
  - Adjust wording to better reflect their voice

What the system does

- Preserves the original draft version
- Tracks student edits separately
- Allows regeneration if the student wants to refine further

Why this matters

- Reinforces student ownership

- Ensures authenticity
- Prevents misrepresentation

7.5 Step 5: Student Approves and Locks the Story

What the student experiences

- When satisfied, the student clicks **Approve and Lock**
- The system clearly explains that:
  - This version will be used for publishing
  - Further changes will require staff involvement

What the system does

- Records explicit approval
- Locks the approved text
- Marks the story as ready for publishing steps

Why this matters

- Creates a clear consent checkpoint
- Protects students from accidental changes
- Provides MAP with a defensible approval record

7.6 Step 6: Student Uploads Photo (Optional)

What the student experiences

- The student is invited (not required) to upload a photo
- Consent options are clearly displayed:
  - Use in PDF or internal materials
  - Use on public-facing MAP platforms

What the system does

- Securely accepts the photo
- Stores consent selections alongside the image
- Allows the student to skip this step entirely

Why this matters

- Respects student comfort and privacy
- Separates storytelling from image requirements
- Supports multiple publishing formats

7.7 Step 7: Student Reviews the Publish Preview

What the student experiences

- A **publish preview** is displayed
- The preview shows:
  - The approved story text
  - The uploaded photo (if provided)
  - A layout approximating how the story will appear when published

What the system does

- Pulls the final approved story
- Retrieves a secure preview of the photo
- Presents the combined view for final confirmation

Why this matters

- Eliminates surprises
- Builds trust and transparency
- Gives students confidence in the final outcome

7.8 Step 8: Final Submission for MAP Publishing

What the student experiences

- The student submits the final preview
- A confirmation message explains:
  - The story has been received
  - MAP staff may review before publishing
  - No further action is required

What the system does

- Marks the story as publish-ready
- Makes it available for MAP communications workflows
- Retains all consent and approval records

Why this matters

- Cleanly hands off stories to MAP
- Minimizes staff follow-up
- Enables consistent, scalable publishing

7.9 Summary of Student-Centered Design

This workflow is intentionally designed to be:

- **Simple** — no accounts, no long forms
- **Respectful** — students control their story
- **Flexible** — text or voice, photo optional
- **Transparent** — preview before publishing

- **Scalable** — minimal staff intervention required

It balances ease of participation with MAP's need for quality, consistency, and governance.

Transition to Next Section

The next section will describe:

- **How MAP staff interact with the system**
- What oversight remains
- How publishing and communications workflows are supported

This ensures clarity not only for students, but for internal teams responsible for stewardship and storytelling.

8. Governance & Controls (Proposed Framework)

This section describes the **governance, oversight, and control mechanisms** that are intentionally designed into the proposed student story platform.

The goal is to ensure that: - Students retain control over their own stories - MAP maintains editorial and publishing authority - No content is published automatically or without review - The system aligns with institutional expectations around consent, privacy, and communications

This governance framework is foundational to the proposal and is designed to scale responsibly.

8.1 Student Consent and Ownership

Proposed approach

- Student participation is entirely **voluntary**
- Consent is captured at multiple, clearly defined points
- Students retain ownership of their narrative until they explicitly approve it

Key consent checkpoints include:

1. **Participation consent**
    - Students opt in by choosing to begin the interview
    - No story is created unless the student actively participates
2. **Story approval consent**
    - Students must explicitly approve and lock the final story text
    - Drafts are never considered publishable
3. **Photo consent (separate and optional)**
    - Photo upload is optional
    - Consent for photo use is granular (e.g., internal vs public use)

Why this matters

- Prevents accidental or implied consent
- Aligns with best practices for ethical AI use
- Protects both students and MAP institutionally

8.2 No Automatic Publishing

Proposed safeguard

- The system will **never automatically publish** a story
- AI-generated content is always treated as a *draft*
- Student approval alone does not trigger public publication

Intended design principle

AI assists the process, but humans retain authority.

Why this matters

- Prevents unreviewed content from appearing publicly
- Reinforces MAP's role as steward of student narratives
- Reduces reputational and compliance risk

8.3 MAP Editorial Authority

Proposed role of MAP and Communications teams

- MAP retains full editorial authority over all stories
- Stories submitted through the system are:
  - Reviewed
  - Curated
  - Published according to MAP standards and timelines

Editorial controls include:

- Ability to:
  - Select which stories to publish
  - Edit for clarity or length (with appropriate safeguards)
  - Align stories with broader communications goals
- Option to:
  - Hold stories for later publication
  - Decline publication if needed

Why this matters

- Ensures consistency with MAP voice and branding
- Preserves professional communications standards
- Integrates with existing MAP publishing workflows

8.4 Communications Review and Oversight

Proposed post-pilot integration

- During and after the pilot phase:
  - Communications staff will review selected stories
  - Feedback will be used to refine story structure and workflow
- No change to current communications approval chains is assumed without agreement

Intended outcome

- AI-assisted collection reduces staff burden
- Editorial judgment remains firmly human-led

- The system supports, rather than replaces, communications expertise

8.5 Auditability and Accountability

Proposed system design includes:

- Clear tracking of:
  - Student approvals
  - Consent selections
  - Story versions (draft, edited, approved)
- Ability to demonstrate:
  - When consent was given
  - Which version was approved
  - What content was ultimately submitted

Why this matters

- Supports institutional accountability
- Enables transparent review if questions arise
- Aligns with public-sector expectations for documentation

8.6 Summary of Governance Principles

The proposed governance model is intentionally designed to be:

- **Consent-driven** — students control their participation
- **Human-governed** — MAP retains authority at every stage
- **Non-automated** — nothing is published by default
- **Transparent** — approvals and versions are traceable
- **Scalable** — controls hold even as volume increases

These principles ensure that the platform can grow responsibly while maintaining trust with students, staff, and leadership.

Transition to Next Section

The next section will describe:

- **Evaluation criteria and success metrics**
- How MAP can assess whether the pilot meets its goals
- What evidence will guide decisions about broader adoption.

9. Evaluation Criteria (Proposed Pilot Assessment Framework)

This section outlines the **criteria that will be used to evaluate the pilot** and determine whether the proposed student story platform should move forward to broader implementation.

The evaluation framework is designed to answer one central question:

> Does this approach meaningfully improve MAP's ability to collect high-quality, student-approved stories at scale, while reducing staff burden?

To answer that question, the pilot will be evaluated across **five complementary dimensions**: student experience, story quality, engagement modality, operational efficiency, and scalability readiness.

9.1 Student Participation and Completion

What will be evaluated

- Number of students who start the interview
- Number of students who complete the interview
- Number of students who approve a final story

Why this matters

- Indicates whether students are willing to engage with the process
- Helps identify friction points in the workflow
- Ensures the experience is accessible and not overly burdensome

Key signals of success

- A majority of invited students complete the interview once started
- Students are able to move from interview to approval without staff assistance
- Drop-off points are identifiable and actionable

9.2 Story Quality and Consistency

What will be evaluated

- Alignment of generated stories with MAP storytelling standards
- Consistency of structure and tone across stories
- Clarity, completeness, and narrative flow of approved stories

How quality will be assessed

- Qualitative review by MAP and Communications staff
- Comparison with previously published manual stories
- Identification of common edits or revisions needed

Why this matters

- Ensures AI assistance enhances—not degrades—story quality

- Confirms the platform produces publish-ready narratives
- Supports brand and communications integrity

9.3 Engagement Modality: Voice vs Text

What will be evaluated

- Student preference for text-based vs voice-based responses
- Completion rates by modality
- Differences in story richness or length between modalities

Why this matters

- Informs accessibility and equity considerations
- Helps determine whether voice interaction meaningfully increases participation
- Guides future investment decisions around voice technologies

Intended outcome

- Evidence-based guidance on whether both modalities should be supported long-term

9.4 Staff Time and Operational Efficiency

What will be evaluated

- Reduction in staff time required per story
- Elimination of manual interview scheduling
- Decrease in back-and-forth communications for story collection

Comparison point

- Current manual process (counselor or staff-led interviews)
- AI-assisted workflow with student self-service

Why this matters

- Directly addresses the scalability challenge
- Quantifies return on investment for MAP and CCCCO
- Demonstrates whether the platform frees staff for higher-value work

9.5 Readiness for Scale

What will be evaluated

- System reliability during pilot usage
- Ability to handle multiple concurrent interviews
- Clarity of governance, consent, and publishing handoffs

Indicators of readiness

- No critical workflow failures
- Clear ownership across technical, communications, and MAP teams
- Minimal manual intervention required to move stories through the pipeline

Why this matters

- Ensures the pilot is not a one-off solution
- Confirms the approach can support MAP's long-term storytelling goals
- Provides confidence for expansion to additional populations

9.6 Pilot Evaluation Outputs

At the conclusion of the pilot, the following outputs are expected:

- Summary metrics across all evaluation categories
- Qualitative feedback from students and staff
- Examples of approved, publishable stories
- Recommendations for:
  - Workflow refinements
  - Technical enhancements
  - Governance adjustments
  - Scale-up decisions

These findings will inform MAP leadership's decision on whether—and how—to proceed with broader deployment.

Transition to Next Section

The next section will outline:

- **Proposed timeline and milestones**
- What MAP can expect during each phase of the pilot
- How progress will be tracked and communicated.

10. Next Steps (Upon Approval)

This section outlines the **proposed sequence of actions** that would take place *only after formal approval of the pilot*.
The steps are designed to minimize rework, ensure alignment across teams, and allow MAP to move forward with confidence.

Each step builds intentionally on the previous one, with clear checkpoints before advancing.

10.1 Confirm Pilot Cohort

What will happen

- Identify a small group of participating colleges
- Confirm a target cohort of approximately **20–50 CPL students**
- Align with local staff on timing and outreach expectations

Why this matters

- Keeps the pilot intentionally small and manageable
- Ensures participating students represent realistic CPL use cases
- Allows MAP to observe variation across colleges without statewide rollout risk

10.2 Finalize Student Interview Question Set

What will happen

- Review the proposed interview question framework provided with this proposal
- Compare against:
  - Existing MAP questions
  - Current published stories
  - Communications priorities
- Refine wording, ordering, and optional prompts as needed

Why this matters

- Ensures the conversational interview reflects MAP voice and values
- Allows MAP to retain ownership over narrative framing
- Prevents downstream editing or rework

Important note:
The proposed question set is intentionally presented as a *starting point*, not a fixed or locked design.
MAP feedback at this stage directly shapes the student experience.

10.3 Align Publishing and Communications Workflow

What will happen

- Define how approved stories move from the platform to MAP publishing
- Clarify:
  - Review responsibilities
  - Editorial checkpoints
  - Publication timing and formats
- Align expectations with Communications stakeholders

Why this matters

- Ensures AI-assisted stories integrate cleanly into existing MAP processes
- Avoids surprises or workflow friction post-pilot
- Establishes a repeatable pattern for future expansion

10.4 Launch Pilot (Limited Deployment)

What will happen

- Send interview invitations to the pilot cohort
- Monitor system usage and student progress
- Provide light-touch support if needed (without active staff intervention)

What will *not* happen

- No automatic public publishing
- No statewide exposure
- No permanent commitments beyond the pilot scope

Why this matters

- Allows MAP to observe real student behavior
- Surfaces usability and workflow insights early
- Maintains full control throughout the pilot period

10.5 Review Outcomes and Determine Scale-Up Path

What will happen

- Review pilot evaluation results (see Section 9)
- Assess:
  - Student experience
  - Story quality
  - Staff effort reduction
  - Operational readiness
- Decide on next steps, such as:
  - Refinements before expansion
  - Additional pilot cohorts
  - Broader rollout planning

Why this matters

- Grounds decisions in evidence rather than assumptions
- Allows MAP to proceed incrementally
- Preserves flexibility for future design choices

10.6 Summary of Decision Flow

Approval of this proposal enables MAP to:

1. Validate the concept at small scale

2. Shape the student narrative experience directly

3. Observe real outcomes before committing to expansion

No irreversible decisions are made at this stage.
Each step includes a natural checkpoint for review, adjustment, or pause.

Transition to Closing

The following section will summarize:

- Why this project is strategically aligned with MAP goals
- How it serves as a foundational building block for future initiatives
- Why this is an appropriate time to proceed with a controlled pilot

11. Why This Proposal Matters

This proposal represents a deliberate shift in how MAP approaches student storytelling—from a labor-intensive, ad hoc process to a **scalable, student-centered storytelling infrastructure**.

11.1 From Manual Effort to Sustainable Capability

Today, collecting student stories requires:

- Significant staff coordination
- One-on-one interviews
- Manual drafting and editing
- Back-and-forth approvals
- Bottlenecks in publishing

As a result, story collection is slow, inconsistent, and difficult to scale—despite strong interest and clear institutional value.

This proposal moves MAP toward a future where:

- Students share their stories directly, in their own words
- Staff effort is focused on *review and stewardship*, not transcription
- Story collection can grow without proportional increases in workload

11.2 A Foundational Building Block, Not a One-Off Tool

Importantly, this is **not** a single-purpose application.

The proposed pilot establishes a **reusable pattern** that can support future MAP initiatives, including:

- Credit for Prior Learning (CPL)
- Veterans
- Apprenticeships
- Rising Scholars
- Foster Youth
- Other student populations where lived experience matters

By investing once in a well-governed storytelling framework, MAP creates long-term flexibility and reuse.

11.3 Low Risk, High Learning Value

Early exploratory validation has already demonstrated that:

- Students can complete guided interviews independently
- Text and voice responses both work effectively
- Draft stories can be generated reliably from student input
- Consent and approval workflows can be clearly enforced

As a result, the proposed pilot does **not** ask MAP to take a leap of faith on technical feasibility.

Instead, the pilot allows MAP to focus on:

- Student experience
- Narrative quality
- Editorial alignment
- Publishing workflows
- Governance and consent

This is where institutional insight and leadership matter most.

11.4 Alignment with MAP's Strategic Goals

This proposal directly supports MAP's broader objectives by:

- Elevating student voices at scale
- Reducing inequities in who gets represented
- Increasing consistency and quality of published stories
- Supporting long-term communications and advocacy goals
- Laying groundwork for future AI-enabled MAP initiatives

It transforms storytelling from an occasional effort into a **strategic capability**.

11.5 Why Proceed Now

Proceeding with this pilot now allows MAP to:

- Act while momentum and alignment are strong
- Shape the system intentionally before broader adoption
- Learn quickly, at small scale, with minimal risk
- Establish leadership in responsible, student-centered AI use

Delaying would likely mean continuing to invest staff time in processes that do not scale—without gaining the learning benefits this pilot offers.

11.6 Closing Perspective

At its core, this proposal is about **listening at scale**.

It offers MAP a way to responsibly amplify student voices, honor lived experience, and do so in a manner that is sustainable, governed, and aligned with institutional values.

Approval of this pilot does not commit MAP to permanent change.
It commits MAP to **learning**, **intentional design**, and **evidence-based decision-making**.

That is why this proposal matters.